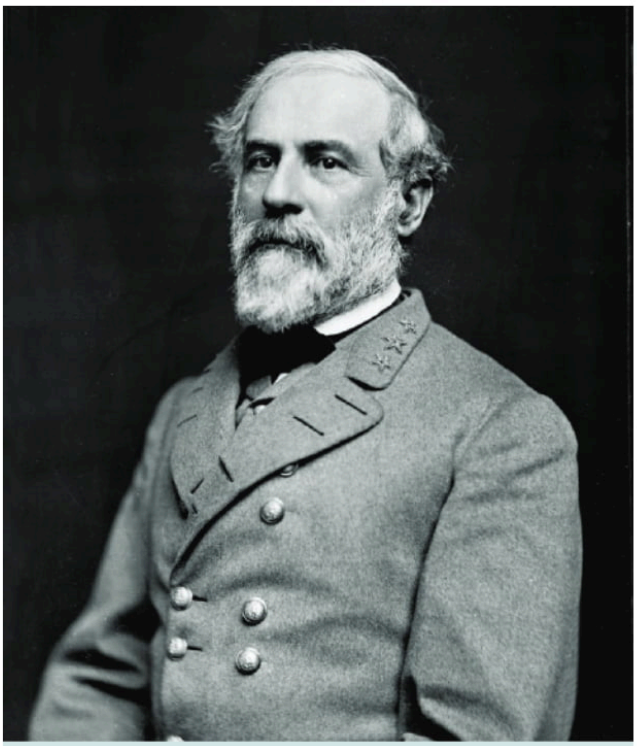
1.2 An Early Confederate Victory

Sometimes you jump into something before you're really ready. Without enough time to make a plan or devise a strategy, you could find that you just have to "wing it." In a way, that's what happened to the Union and Confederate armies.

MAIN IDEA Confederate forces gained an early victory by winning the Battle of Bull Run.



Robert E. Lee

Born into a celebrated Virginia family, Robert E. Lee wanted to make a name for himself. He enrolled in the U.S. Military Academy at West Point in New York and was one of only six soldiers in his class who graduated with a clean record of behavior. After graduating, Lee met and married a descendant of Martha Washington, George Washington's wife. During the Mexican-American War, Lee impressed his commanding officer, General Winfield Scott, with his keen military mind. He became an officer in the Confederate Army after turning down Lincoln's offer to command the Union Army. His loyalty to his home state outweighed the president's request.

PREPARING FOR WAR

War had begun, but neither the Union nor the Confederacy was actually prepared for it. In April 1861, the Union forces included only 16,000 professional soldiers, while the Confederacy had fewer than 2,000. Both sides quickly took steps to **mobilize**, or organize and prepare troops for active service.

The North and the South enlisted troops at the local and state levels. A local leader would encourage men to join and serve under his command, or a group of men would get together and elect their commander. Many military units also formed along ethnic lines. Some northern regiments consisted only of European immigrants who communicated in their native language. Germans were the largest European immigrant group fighting for the Union. European immigrants also fought for the South, and a Texas regiment consisting of Mexicans called the Tejas soon joined the Confederate cause as well. Mobilization helped swell the ranks on both sides, but neither army was at full strength.

THE BATTLE OF BULL RUN

The armies were put to the test in July 1861. Hoping to bring a swift end to the war, Lincoln decided to send Union forces to seize Richmond. To carry out his plan, Lincoln first ordered General Irvin McDowell to attack the Confederate forces in Manassas, Virginia, a town less than 100 miles from Richmond. McDowell and his troops were in Washington, D.C., only 40 miles east of Manassas. But McDowell didn't believe his 35,000 volunteers were ready for battle, so he and his troops left

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.



The first official Confederate flag is shown at the left. Often called the "Stars and Bars," it sometimes caused confusion on the battlefield because it looked so much like the U.S. flag. The flag below was first flown by a Virginia regiment. Soon other regiments began using it, but the Confederacy never officially adopted the flag.



Washington, D.C., more than a week later than planned. When the Confederate general stationed in Manassas, P.G.T. Beauregard, learned of the delay, he sent for help. Soon 11,000 more Confederate soldiers arrived to strengthen his forces.

The battle began on July 21, when Union forces crossed a small creek called Bull Run to attack the Confederates. As the Confederate soldiers charged, they unleashed a high-pitched battle cry that could be heard for miles. The earsplitting cry came to be known as the "rebel yell." Many Union soldiers wrote in letters and diaries about the terror the scream inspired.

During the battle, Confederate general Thomas Jackson and his forces filled a gap in the line of Confederate soldiers. He held the line so bravely that another general told his men to take heart from the sight of Jackson, "standing like a stone wall!" Jackson would be known by the nickname **Stonewall Jackson** for the rest of his life. Meanwhile, **J.E.B. Stuart**, the leader of the Virginia Confederate **cavalry**, or soldiers on horseback, watched Union movements on a hill overlooking the battlefield. At a critical point in the battle, Stuart's cavalry charged and scattered the Union **infantry**, or foot soldiers. The charge forced the Union troops to retreat to Washington, D.C.

The Confederacy won the battle, but both sides suffered heavy casualties: about 3,000 soldiers for the North and more than 1,700 for the South. Another battle at Bull Run would take place more than a year later. Once again, the Confederates, under General **Robert E. Lee**, would win but with staggering casualties: nearly 15,000 for the Union and 9,000 for the Confederacy. These extremely high casualty rates continued to make the war unpopular in the North. Lincoln knew it would be a long and grueling war.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the North and the South prepare for the war?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did the first Battle of Bull Run affect the course of the early part of the war?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** How did this battle reflect the beginnings of a broad pattern of leadership in the North and the South?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.